

Cynefin Framework

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Match response to problem complexity

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Cynefin Framework sorts situations into domains — clear, complicated, complex and chaotic — so that leaders match their response to the kind of problem they face rather than applying one approach to all.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Created by Dave Snowden while at IBM, set out with Mary Boone in a 2007 Harvard Business Review article.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

It was developed to counter the error of treating every problem as merely complicated, when complex problems require probing and adaptation.

FIGURE 1 · CYNEFIN FRAMEWORK

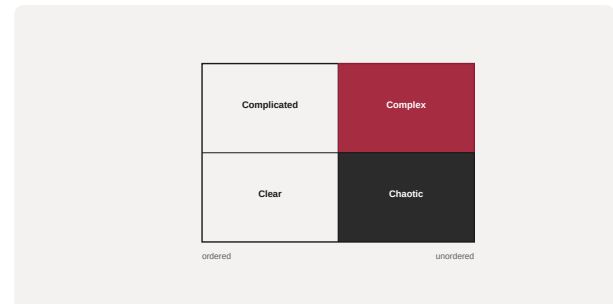


Figure 1. A schematic of the Cynefin Framework as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

A situation is placed in a domain; complex problems are met with safe-to-fail experiments and amplification of what works, not detailed up-front planning.

WHEN IT IS USED

When deciding how to respond to disruption and uncertainty.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Leaders, strategists and decision-makers.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It introduces a sense-making typology that prevents misapplied management approaches, especially in the complex domain where disruption lives.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

OODA Loop (Enterprise) · Slibrary 17

Agile Operating Model · Slibrary 17

Sense-Respond Loop · Slibrary 17

Real Options Lens · Slibrary 17

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Snowden, D.J. and Boone, M.E. (2007) 'A leader's framework for decision making', Harvard Business Review, 85(11).

Kurtz, C.F. and Snowden, D.J. (2003) 'The new dynamics of strategy', IBM Systems Journal, 42(3).